

Murmuration on My Mind: A Rigorous Approach to Modeling Kinematics and Information in Starling Flocks

Caiman Moreno-Earle
cmorenoe@caltech.edu

California Institute of Technology

November 24, 2025

Abstract

In this hurdle, we explore the dynamics and information propagation of starling murmurations. I introduce the Swarm on a Sphere (SOS) model to calculate the number of neighbors each bird tracks and initial alignment effects on flocking behavior ($n = 6$). I then use Lyapunov Theory to prove global asymptotic stability of flocking behavior. The Heisenberg model, and specifically Glauber dynamics, is adapted from its usual appearance in stat mech for magnetic systems to model the speed of information propagation and response to predator attacks. I use this to determine the speed of information propagation at ($\approx 0.6s$ to propagate across the swarm), and determine a predator attack response threshold based on field strength and frequency of attack.

Contents

1	Introduction	1
2	Theory / Background	2
3	Swarm on a Sphere Analysis	3
3.1	Computational Experiments	4
3.1.1	Implementation	4
3.1.2	Computational Results	6
3.1.3	Swarm Collisions	7
3.2	Analytical Results	9
3.3	Conclusion from SOS Analysis	10
4	Heisenberg Model Analysis	10
4.1	Theory	10
4.2	Computational Experiments	12
4.3	Predator Attack Analysis	13
5	Conclusion	14
6	AI Use Disclaimer	15

1 Introduction

In this hurdle, we explore the dynamics and information propagation of starling murmurations. I begin by introducing the theoretical kinematic dynamics and rigorously defining properties of solutions. I then analyze the system with two approaches, the Swarm on a Sphere (SOS) model and the Heisenberg model.

The SOS model is used to analyze short-term flocking behavior and stability. In this section, I determine the number of neighbors that each bird tracks, the effect of initial alignment on flocking behavior, how swarms initially form, and finally use Lyapunov Theory to prove the asymptotic stability of flocking behavior.

The Heisenberg model, and specifically Glauber dynamics, is adapted from its usual appearance in stat mech for magnetic systems to model the speed of information propagation and response to predator attacks. In this section, I determine the speed of information propagation to take approximately $\approx 0.6s$ to propagate across the swarm, and determine a predator attack response threshold based on field strength and frequency of attack.

2 Theory / Background

We begin by establishing the theoretical kinematic dynamics governing the swarm of birds, and then using these dynamics to infer the flow of information through the system. Analysis of several videos of swarming shows that a full swarm may be comprised of several sub-swarms. For the purposes of this paper, we will denote each of these sub-swarms as a *component* [You25].

Definition 2.1. A **component** is defined as the tuple (C, r) , a set of birds, C , such that any bird in the component may be reached from any other bird in the component via a sequence of birds, each within radius r of the next.

Assumption 2.2. *All swarms are composed of a finite number of components.*

Rationale: *There exists a finite number of birds in the universe (hopefully) and thus even in the worst-case scenario where each bird is its own component, there will still be a finite number of components.*

Assumption 2.3. *The behavior of birds within a component (C, r) is independent of the behavior of birds outside the component.*

Rationale: *Information and therefore influence may only be transmitted bird to bird within a limited radius, for convenience assume r is chosen to be less than or equal to this radius.*

Under assumptions 2.1 and 2.2 it suffices to analyze the behavior of a single component. So, for now, consider a single component (C, r) . Let $N = |C| < \infty$ be the number of birds in the component.

Definition 2.4. A **state** at time t is a vector

$$\Psi(t) = (\theta_1(t), \theta_2(t), \dots, \theta_N(t), X_1(t), X_2(t), \dots, X_N(t)) \in \mathbb{R}^{6N},$$

where $\theta_i(t), X_i(t) \in \mathbb{R}^3$ represent the heading and position of bird i in space at time t (heading taken to be normalized).

Let Ψ_0 be the initial state of the system at time $t = 0$. The evolution of the system can then be modeled by the following initial value problem

$$\begin{cases} \frac{d\Psi(t)}{dt} = F(\Psi(t)), \\ \Psi(0) = \Psi_0 \end{cases} \quad (2.1)$$

where $F : \mathbb{R}^{6N} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^{6N}$ is a function that encodes interactions between birds in the system.

Assumption 2.5. *F is continuous and differentiable in Ψ on a neighborhood of Ψ_0 .*

Rationale: *Being a physical system, between macroscopic objects (birds) we should expect the interactions to be continuous and at least C^1 smooth.*

Assumption 2.6. *Under small time scales, the relative separations, $\|X_i - X_j\|$, of birds in the swarm can be considered constant.*

Rationale: *Studies have determined that topological properties (i.e. closest neighbors, not metric distance of closest neighbors) matter more in bird flocking behavior than metric distance, so for small time scales, we can assume that distances between birds remain constant without affecting the end behavior of the system [Bal+08]*

Looking at assumption 2.5 let us now consider its implications. First we can define the separation $N \times N$ matrix $K(t)$, constructed as $K_{i,j}(t) = \|X_i(t) - X_j(t)\|$:

$$K(t) = \begin{bmatrix} \|X_1(t) - X_1(t)\| & \|X_1(t) - X_2(t)\| & \cdots & \|X_1(t) - X_N(t)\| \\ \|X_2(t) - X_1(t)\| & \|X_2(t) - X_2(t)\| & \cdots & \|X_2(t) - X_N(t)\| \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ \|X_N(t) - X_1(t)\| & \|X_N(t) - X_2(t)\| & \cdots & \|X_N(t) - X_N(t)\| \end{bmatrix} \quad (2.2)$$

Under a small time scale $t \in (t_0, t_0 + \delta)$, we can consider $K(t)$ to be a constant matrix by assumption 2.5, which we will denote K . The final simplification we make is to further restrict positions $X_i(t)$ to be in a lattice structure, to simplify analysis and neighborhood computations.

Assumption 2.7. *Under a small time scale, the positions $X_i(t)$ of birds in the component are fixed on a lattice structure in $\mathbb{R}^3$.*

Rationale: From assumption 2.5 we know that under a small time scale, the relative separations of birds remain constant, now also referring to [Bal+08] we know that birds focus more on topological neighbors rather than metric neighbors, so since got this model, we are more concerned about turning and heading information rather than exact positions we can assume a lattice structure.

Now, for a small time scale, equation (2.1) can be rewritten as a system of first-order ODEs

$$\begin{cases} \frac{d\theta_i(t)}{dt} = f_i(\theta_1(t), \theta_2(t), \dots, \theta_N(t); K), & i = 1, 2, \dots, N, \\ \theta_i(0) = \theta_{i,0}, & i = 1, 2, \dots, N, \end{cases} \quad (2.3)$$

Theorem 2.8 (Existence and Uniqueness of Solutions to (2.3)). *Let F be as defined in (2.1), then there exists a unique local solution corresponding to the IVP (2.3)*

Proof. From assumption 2.5, we know that F is differentiable and therefore by MVT locally Lipschitz in Ψ on a neighborhood of Ψ_0 . Now it follows that for each f_i in (2.3), f_i is also locally Lipschitz in θ_j on a neighborhood of $\theta_{j,0}$. Therefore by Picard–Lindelöf theorem, there exist unique solutions (2.3) for small time scales. $\square$

The remainder of this paper will focus on analyzing the solutions to this system of equations, with a second order variation of this system being considered in section [TBD].

3 Swarm on a Sphere Analysis

As discussed in the introduction, the two main methods we will use to analyze the first-order system (2.3), are the Swarm on a Sphere (SOS) model and the Heisenberg model. First, we will examine this system through the SOS approach. To build up to SOS we first introduce the Kuramoto model. The Kuramoto model is a model in mathematical physics to describe a system of synchronizing oscillators.

$$\begin{cases} \frac{d\psi_i}{dt} = \omega_i + \frac{1}{N} \sum_{j=1}^N R_{ij} \sin(\psi_j - \psi_i) \\ \psi_i(0) = \psi_{i,0} \end{cases} \quad (3.1)$$

Where ψ_i represents the phase of the i th oscillator, ω_i its natural frequency, and R_{ij} the coupling strength between oscillators i and j .

While I would have loved to use Kuramoto to model the heading in (2.3), the main limitation is that $\psi_i(t) \in \mathbb{R}^2$, while accurately modeling (2.3) requires $\theta_i(t) \in \mathbb{R}^3$ (again assumed normalized).

The generalization of this model to $d - \dim$ is the Swarm on a Sphere (SOS) model [Olf06], which models coupled oscillators on $\mathbb{R}^d$. Where in our context $d = 2$ and the oscillators represent the heading of each bird in the swarm. SOS is given by the following

$$\frac{dx_i}{dt} = \sum_{j=1}^N R_{ij}(x_j - \langle x_j, x_i \rangle x_i) \quad (3.2)$$

Where $x_i \in \mathbb{R}^d$ is the unit vector of bird i in the swarm, and R_{ij} is the interaction strength between birds i and j . We get that $\theta_i = x_i$. and thus f_i is given by the RHS of (3.2). Before analyzing (3.2) analytically, we first numerically experiment to determine key parameters that affect the behavior of the system, then we analyze the system to determine stability and long term behavior of solutions.

3.1 Computational Experiments

3.1.1 Implementation

The goal of the computational experiments was to numerically determine 2 key parameters that affect the behavior, namely the initial alignment and the interaction matrix R .

Definition 3.1. The **initial alignment** of a component (C, r) is defined as

$$A = \frac{1}{N} \left\| \sum_{i=1}^N \theta_{i,0} \right\| \in [0, 1].$$

Where $A = 1$ represents perfect initial alignment (all birds facing the same direction) and $A = 0$ represents initial disalignment (birds in random directions).

To accomplish this I wrote a python simulation that numerically solves (3.2) on a 3D lattice using scipy's IVP solver. The simulation works by approximating a component (C, r) on a $X \times Y \times Z$ 3D lattice with edge length r between lattice points, and $N = X \times Y \times Z$. Each vertex represents a bird with an associated heading (unit vector in $\mathbb{R}^3$).

To initialize the simulation takes in the size of the flock (X, Y, Z) , an initial alignment A which is what determines the distribution of initial headings of the birds, and an interaction matrix R . Since from [Bal+08] we know that interactions are based on topological neighbors, the interaction matrix R is constructed based off of **order**, and **weight**.

Definition 3.2. The **order** of the interaction matrix R on a lattice L , is defined as the maximum lattice "hops" two birds may be and still interact. (i.e. order 1 means birds only interact with direct lattice neighbors, order 2 neighbors of neighbors and so on).

Definition 3.3. The **weight** of the interaction matrix R on a lattice L , is defined as the strength of interaction between birds that are at the maximum order of interaction.

As it is obvious that if all else is kept equal, a higher order will lead to quicker swarm alignment, to accurately determine the appropriate order I give every bird a constant "attention", At such that

$$At = \sum_{j=1}^N R_{ij}, \quad \forall i = 1, 2, \dots, N. \quad (3.3)$$

This means that as order increases, the weight must decrease, simulating that it is harder for birds to pay attention to more birds at any given time. I finally ran several simulations over a sweep of initial alignments, orders, and weights, over a variety of flock sizes to determine which values created realistic flocking behavior.

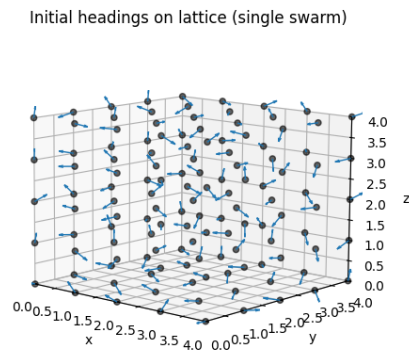


Figure 1: Visualization of Initial Heading Alignments on Lattice

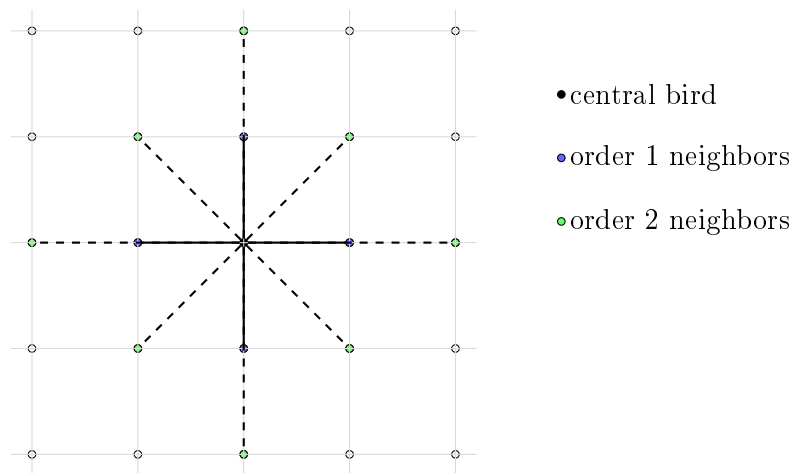


Figure 2: Order 1 and 2 interaction on a 2D lattice (AI Disclaimer: I used chatGPT to generate this tikz drawing)

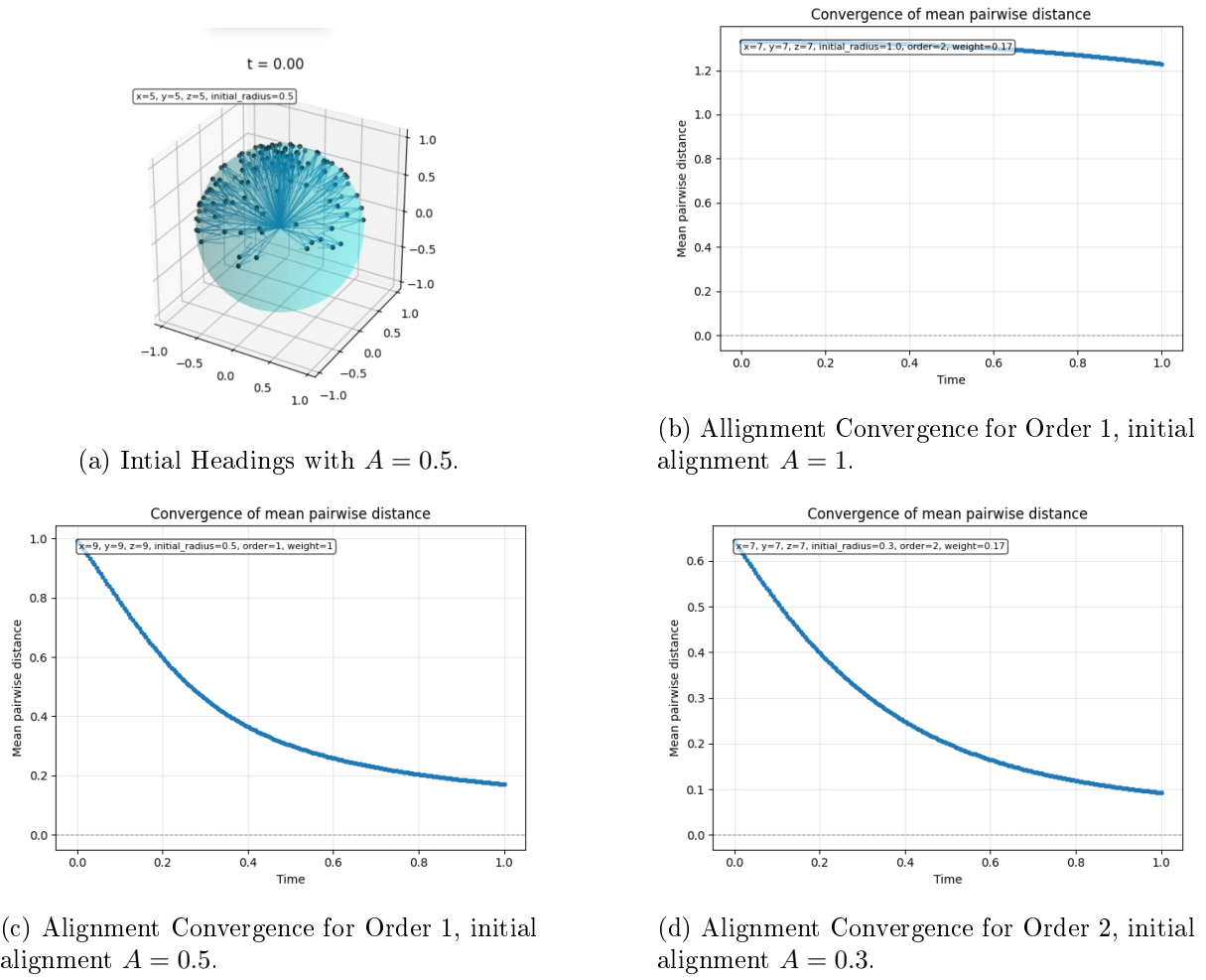


Figure 3: Comparison of swarm behavior for different interaction orders and initial alignments.

3.1.2 Computational Results

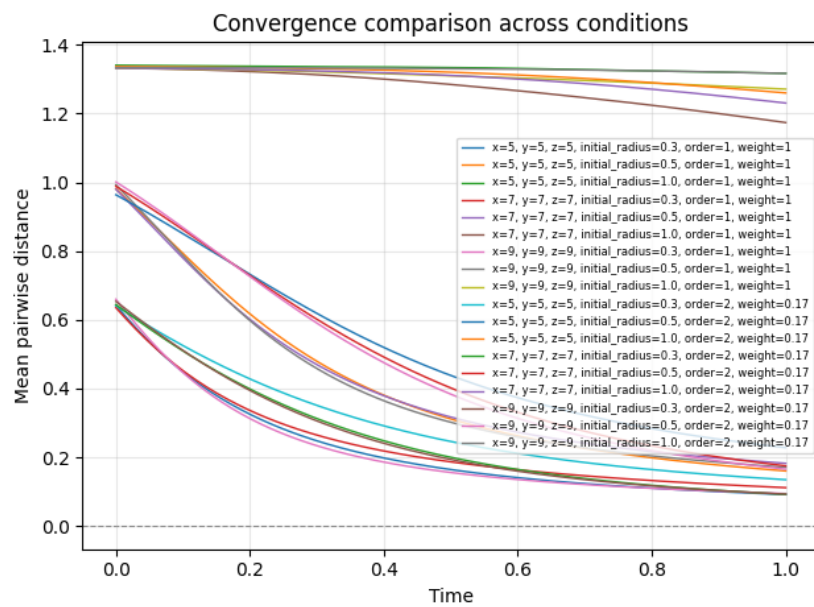


Figure 4: Order 1 simulation result.

From the results of the experiments, and primarily figure 4, we conclude two main results. First, higher order interactions converge slower than order 1 interactions, and second, there appears to be a critical alignment value $A_c > 0.5$ such that for $A < A_c$ swarms converge to alignment, and for $A > A_c$ swarms diverge to disalignment, or at the very least converge too slowly to be realistic. This leads us to assume that real world flocking behavior is best modeled by order 1 interactions with initial alignments below A_c .

While order 1 interactions seem physically intuitive, as you wouldn't expect birds to be tracking huge numbers of neighbors at a time, the results regarding initial alignment raise several questions. While it makes sense that after an initial period of congregation birds in a component would generally be partially aligned, this begs the question of how would flocks initially form, given that initial alignment is likely 0. To answer this question I turned into **swarm collision**.

3.1.3 Swarm Collisions

While playing around with the simulation, I noticed an interesting behavior: if two swarms with low total alignment had subgroups that were highly aligned, then the solution would rapidly converge to alignment. This led me to experiment with the idea of **swarm collision**

Definition 3.4. A **swarm collision** is defined as when two aligned components (C_1, r_1) and (C_2, r_2) physically overlap in position space such that their interactions can be modeled as a single component (C, r) with $C = C_1 \cup C_2$ and $r = \max(r_1, r_2)$, and the lattice representing the system made with birds from C_1 and C_2 is randomly mixed. (ex. figure 5).

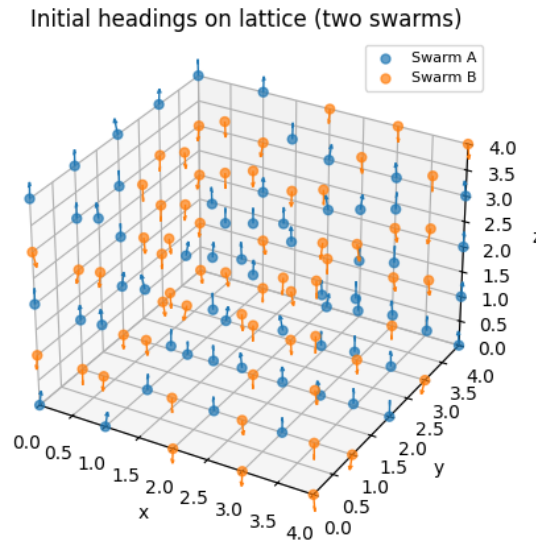


Figure 5: Initial Headings between two colliding swarms

I simulated these collisions and compared their convergence to that of a single swarm with no initial alignment. The results are presented in figure 6 and 7. You can see in figure 7 that despite having near identical initial headings the two swarm collision converges significantly faster than the random initial alignment case.

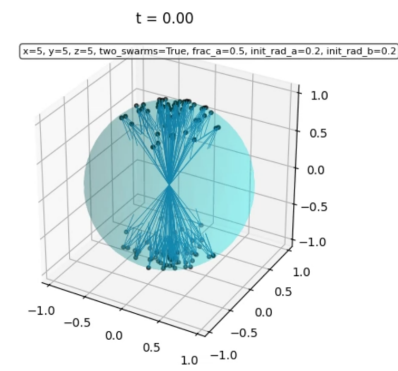
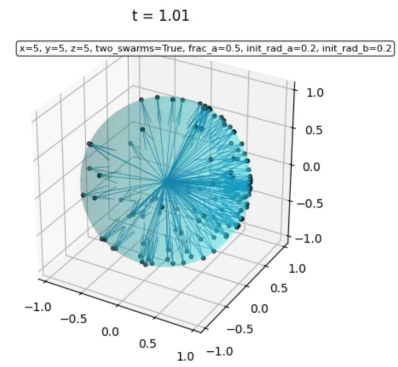
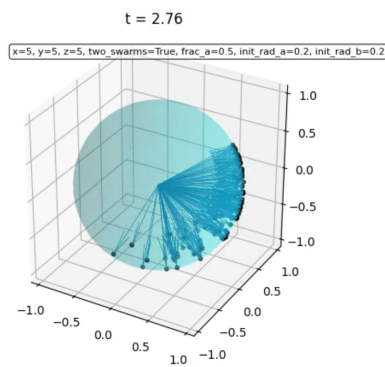
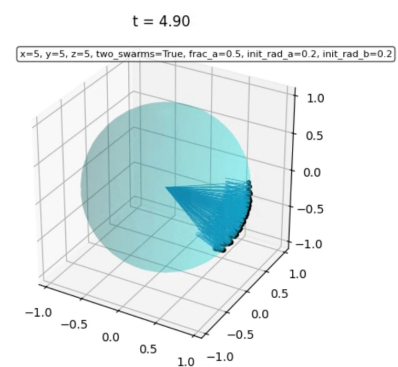
(a) Swarm Collision $t = 0$ (b) Swarm Collision $t = 1$ (c) Swarm Collision $t = 2.5$ (d) Swarm Collision $t = 5$

Figure 6: Evolution of Two Swarm Collision

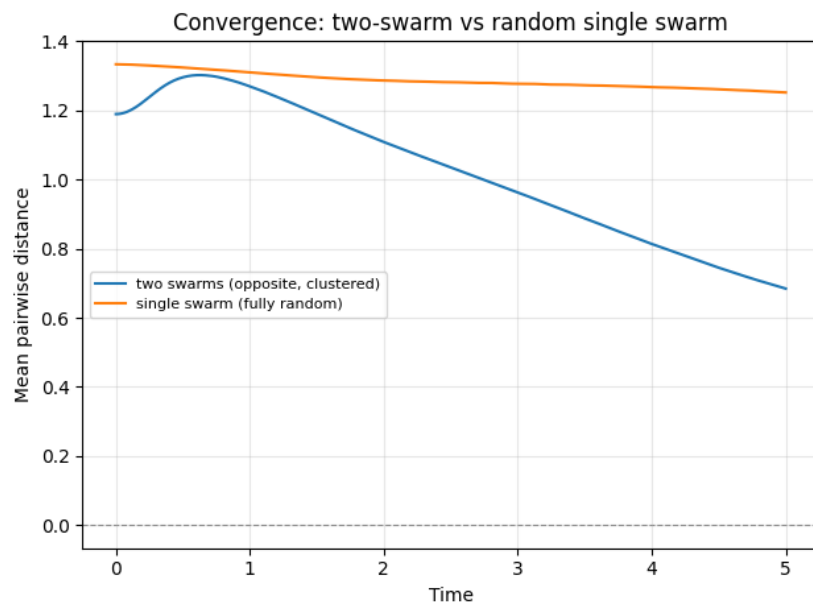


Figure 7: Two Swarm Collision vs Random Initial Alignment

3.2 Analytical Results

From sections (3.1.1) and (3.1.2) we fully define F in (2.1) as the RHS of (3.2) with an order 1 interaction matrix R . Now we can analyze the stability of solutions to (3.2) under these conditions.

First let us determine the asymptotic behavior of solutions to (3.2).

Theorem 3.5 (Solutions to (3.2) are Asymptotically Stable).

Proof. Let $\theta_i(t)$ be a solution to (3.2) with interaction matrix

Let $\Theta = (\theta_1, \theta_2, \dots, \theta_n)$ Define a Lyapunov function

$$V_i(\Theta) = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{j=1}^N R_{ij}(1 - \langle \theta_j, \theta_i \rangle) \quad (3.4)$$

$$V(\Theta) = \sum_{i=1}^N V_i(\Theta) \quad (3.5)$$

Since $\|\theta_i\| = 1 \forall i$ and from (3.1) we have that $R_{ij} \geq 0 \forall i, j$ we have that $V(\Theta) \geq 0 \forall \Theta$, and since R is overlapping (neighborhood of each bird intersects with 6 other birds in 3D) $V(\Theta) = 0$ iff $\theta_i = \theta_j \forall i, j$.

Now we calculate $\dot{V}(\Theta)$ along solutions to (3.2)

$$\dot{V}(\Theta) = \frac{\partial V}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial V}{\partial \Theta} f \quad (3.6)$$

$$= 0 + \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{j=1}^N \frac{\partial V_i}{\partial \theta_j} \cdot f_j \quad (3.7)$$

$$= \sum_{i=1}^N \left\langle \frac{\partial V}{\partial \theta_i}, \dot{\theta}_i \right\rangle \quad (3.8)$$

Now note that since the interaction matrix R is symmetric, we have that

$$\frac{\partial V}{\partial \theta_i} = \sum_{j=1}^N \frac{\partial V_j}{\partial \theta_i} \quad (3.9)$$

$$= - \sum_{j=1}^N R_{ji} \theta_j \quad (3.10)$$

Noting that from (3.2) we have that

$$\dot{\theta}_i = f_i = \sum_{j=1}^N R_{ij} \theta_j - \sum_{j=1}^N \langle \theta_j, \theta_i \rangle \theta_i \quad (3.11)$$

$$= - \frac{\partial V}{\partial \theta_i} + \left\langle \frac{\partial V}{\partial \theta_i}, \theta_i \right\rangle \theta_i \quad (3.12)$$

Letting $P_i = - \sum_{j=1}^N R_{ji} = \frac{\partial V}{\partial \theta_i}$ we can substitute in to (3.8) to get

$$\dot{V}(\Theta) = - \sum_{i=1}^N \langle P_i, P_i - \langle P_i, \theta_i \rangle \theta_i \rangle \quad (3.13)$$

$$= - \sum_{i=1}^N (\|P_i\|^2 - \langle P_i, \theta_i \rangle^2) \quad (3.14)$$

Finally realize that

$$\|f_i\|^2 = \|P_i - \langle P_i, \theta_i \rangle \theta_i\|^2 \quad (3.15)$$

$$= \|P_i\|^2 - 2\langle P_i, \theta_i \rangle^2 + \langle P_i, \theta_i \rangle^2 \|\theta_i\|^2 \quad (3.16)$$

$$= \|P_i\|^2 - \langle P_i, \theta_i \rangle^2 \quad (3.17)$$

Where (3.17) holds since our headings live on the unit sphere. Therefore, substituting (3.17) into (3.15) we get

$$\dot{V}(\Theta) = - \sum_{i=1}^N \|f_i\|^2 \quad (3.18)$$

$$\leq 0 \quad (3.19)$$

Finally, by again noting that R is overlapping and all non-zero entries equal, we have that $\dot{V}(\Theta) = 0$ iff $\theta_i = \theta_j \forall i, j$. Thus since $\theta_i = \theta_j \forall i, j$ is also our condition for $V(\Theta) = 0$. Finally, combined with theorem 2.8 we have that by Lyapunov's direct method that all solutions to (3.2) are global uniformly asymptotically stable. [Mur03] $\square$

3.3 Conclusion from SOS Analysis

From the computational experiments we can conclude a few key points regarding the formation and behavior of bird flocks. First, individual birds in a flock likely only monitor the headings of their order 1 (6 in 3D) neighbors when turning. Next, there exists a critical initial alignment A_c such that flocks with $A < A_c$ will rapidly converge to alignment when flying. Finally the results of section (3.1.3) conclusion leads us to the final (and in my opinion most interesting) conclusion that large bird flocks form from the collision of smaller, already aligned sub-swarms, building the size of the flock over time.

Finally from theorem 3.5, we have that under the SOS model (3.2) all swarms will eventually converge to alignment, regardless of initial alignment. This reinforces the convergence result from the computational experiences, and also clarifies that A_c is not a rigorous critical point rather points with lower initial alignment simply converge many orders faster than those with higher initial alignment.

4 Heisenberg Model Analysis

4.1 Theory

While section 3 answered some key questions regarding flock behavior, primarily flock formation interaction order and stability, the question of the speed of information flow and response to a predator attack remain.

I first thought of using the Heisenberg model when I looked at figure 5 and saw that the headings of the birds in a lattice resembled the spins of particles in an antiferromagnetic material (a material where the lowest energy states are when spins are anti-parallel), and when they reach alignment they resembled the spins of particles in a ferromagnetic material (a material where the lowest energy states are when spins are parallel).

And this is where the Heisenberg model comes in. The Heisenberg model is a statistical mechanics model that models the spins of particles in a lattice ferromagnetic or antiferromagnetic material. The hamiltonian for such a system is given by

$$H = -J \sum_{\langle i, j \rangle} S_i \cdot S_j - \mu \sum_i B \cdot S_i \quad (4.1)$$

Where S_i is the spin vector of particle i , J is the interaction strength between direct neighboring spins $\langle i, j \rangle$, μ is the magnetic moment, and B is an external magnetic field [Pir21]. If $J > 0$, the lowest energy states are those such that all spins are parallel, so the material is ferromagnetic. For our puposes We say our system is "ferromagnetic" because we want the flock to tend to a state where all birds are aligned in the same direction.

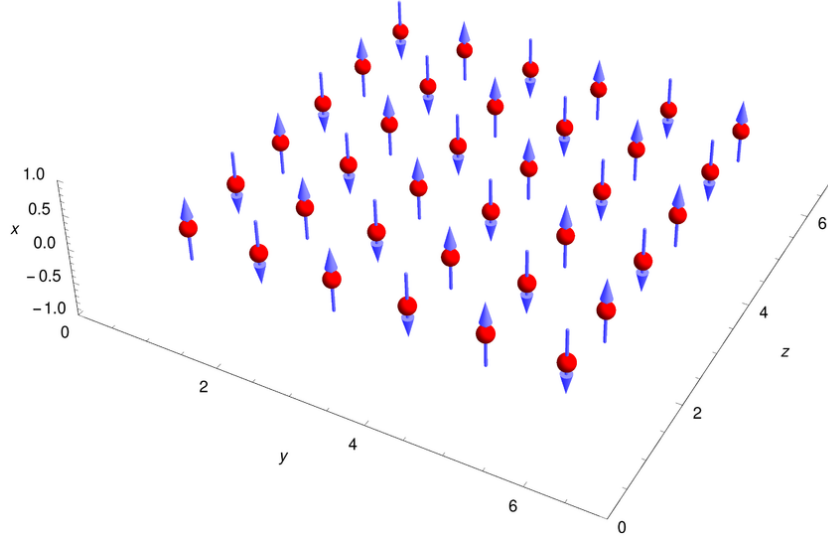


Figure 8: Antiferromagnetic Lattice Representation

Credit: Image from [Beh+16]

Solutions to this system are usually analytically intractable, so we introduce another simplification of the system.

Assumption 4.1. *For the purposes of modeling the speed of information flow, it suffices to consider heading to be a discrete variable in $\{-1, 1\}$.*

Rationale: While in sections 2 and 3, the heading was modeled as a continuous variable in this section, we are less concerned about how birds align and more concerned about how fast they align, and making this simplification allows us to simplify to a model that is analytically tractable.

With this assumption, the Hamiltonian in (4.1) simplifies to the well-studied Ising model Hamiltonian

$$H = -J \sum_{\langle i, j \rangle} s_i s_j - \mu \sum_i B s_i \quad (4.2)$$

Where $s_i \in \{-1, 1\}$. In the absence of global information (i.e. predator attack), we let the external field $B = 0$. reducing to the final form before analysis to

$$H = -J \sum_{\langle i, j \rangle} s_i s_j \quad (4.3)$$

Now to analyze the speed of information flow, we introduce the idea of Glauber Dynamics, which describes how spins flip over time to reach a thermal equilibrium.

define a local field around a point i as

$$h_i = J \sum_{\langle i, j \rangle} s_j \quad (4.4)$$

Then the probability that spin s_i flips to $-s_i$ at time t is given by

$$w(s_i \rightarrow -s_i) = \frac{\alpha}{2} \left(1 - s_i \tanh \left(\frac{h_i}{kT} \right) \right) \quad (4.5)$$

Where α is a constant rate, k is the Boltzmann constant, and T is the temperature of the system [Gla63]. If $P(s, t)$ is the probability of the system being in state s at time t then The expectation value of spin s_i at time t is given by

$$\langle s_i(t) \rangle = \sum_s s_i P(s, t) \quad (4.6)$$

$$(4.7)$$

and time evolution given by

$$\frac{d}{dt} \langle s_i(t) \rangle = -2 \sum_s s_i w(s_i \rightarrow -s_i) P(s, t) \quad (4.8)$$

$$= -\alpha \left(\langle s_i(t) \rangle - \langle \tanh \left(\frac{h_i}{kT} \right) \rangle \right) \quad [\text{NJ89}] \quad (4.9)$$

Now to be able to track alignment convergence similar to the initial alignment section 3, we define the average magnetization $m(t)$ by

$$m(t) = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N \langle s_i(t) \rangle \quad (4.10)$$

Where $|m(t)|$ close to 1 represents high alignment and $|m(t)|$ close to 0 represents low alignment. Substituting in (4.9) gives

$$\frac{d}{dt} m(t) = -\alpha \left(m(t) - \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N \langle \tanh \left(\frac{h_i}{kT} \right) \rangle \right) \quad (4.11)$$

Despite assumption (4.1), this system is still intractable for high dimensions and large N , primarily because interactions between neighbors in the definition of h_i become complex. To simplify this we introduce a mean field approximation.

Assumption 4.2. *The local field h_i can be approximated by the mean field $h_i \approx Jzm(t)$, where z is the number of direct neighbors in the lattice.*

Rationale: On average the interactions with magnetization of neighbors should be the same as interactions with the average magnetization of the system, so $h_i = J \sum_{\langle i,j \rangle} s_j = J \sum_{\langle i,j \rangle} m(t) = Jzm(t)$.

This gives us our final exact and closed average evolution equation

$$\frac{dm}{dt} = -\alpha \left(m - \tanh \left(\frac{Jzm}{kT} \right) \right) \quad (4.12)$$

4.2 Computational Experiments

To actually determine the rate of information transfer, we must first fully define equation (4.12) for our system. Now in quantum physics $\alpha = \frac{1}{\tau}$ where τ represents the time-scale of spin-flips ($\approx 10^{-12}s$) [DP04], so in our case where τ is the physical change of headings we can take τ to be the reaction time of a starling $\approx 0.1s$ [PH77], giving $\alpha \approx 10s^{-1}$. For the 3D dimensional lattice structure we have $z = 6$ direct neighbors, and we can select units (keeping time in seconds,

but affecting temperature) such that $J = 1$ and $k = 1$.

Additionally from our work in section 3 and observation in nature, we know these systems very quickly reach alignment, so we can assume that $T \ll T_c$ where T_c is the critical temperature of the system.

To numerically solve (4.12) I wrote a python script to solve the ODE using scipy's IVP solver under initial conditions of near zero total magnetization ($m_0 = 0.01$). As the exact value of T is unknown I swept T over several orders of magnitude to see its effect on convergence.

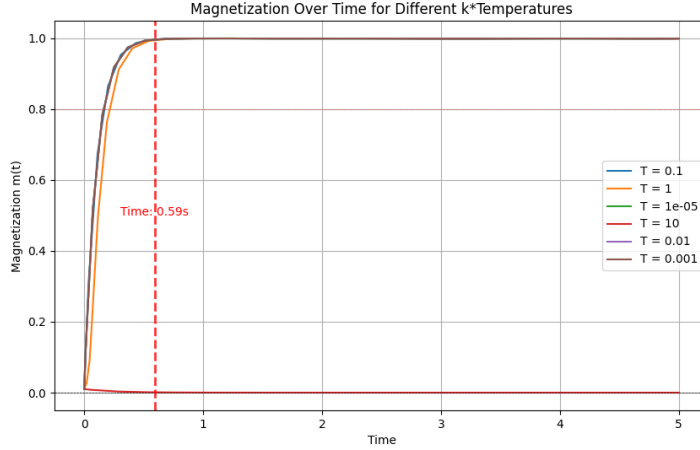


Figure 9: Average Magnetization Convergence for Various Temperatures

From these experiments and as shown in figure 9 we see that below an order of magnitude of $T = 10$ (most certainly the critical temperature) the convergence rate is largely unaffected by temperature and converges to a magnetization (i.e. alignment) of 0.99 in $\approx 0.6s$. This finally gives a numerical estimate of the speed of information transfer in the system.

4.3 Predator Attack Analysis

The final question to answer is how does the flock respond to a predator attack. To model this we reintroduce the external a time-varying field $B(t)$ in (4.2). This oscillating field is meant to represent the predator attacking a flock from a certain direction before flying through turning around and striking again from the opposite direction. For the purposes of this analysis we simply define

$$B(t) = B_0 \sin(\omega t) \quad (4.13)$$

Where B_0 is the strength of the predator attack and ω the frequency of attacks.

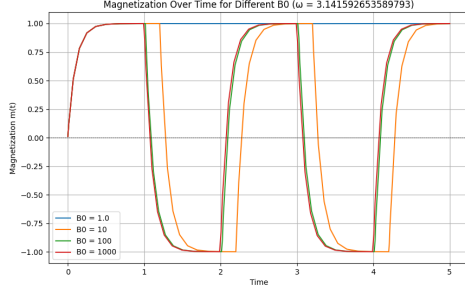
The reintroduction of $B(t)$ changes (4.4) to

$$H = -J \sum_{\langle i,j \rangle} s_i s_j - \mu \sum_i B(t) s_i \quad [\text{Gla63}] \quad (4.14)$$

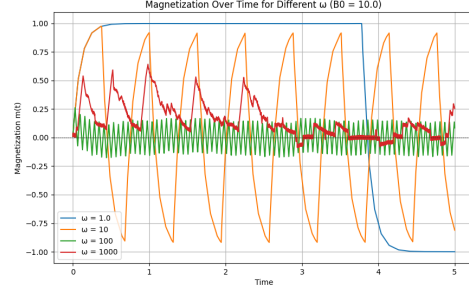
And (4.12) to

$$\frac{dm}{dt} = -\alpha \left(m - \tanh \left(\frac{Jzm + \mu B(t)}{kT} \right) \right) \quad [\text{DP04}] \quad (4.15)$$

I then numerically solved (4.15) for a variety of B_0 and ω values to determine how the flock responds to different types of predator attacks.



(a) Flock Alignment Response in Predator Attacks of Varying Strength



(b) Flock Alignment Response in Predator Attacks of Varying Frequency

Figure 10: Flock Response to Predator Attacks of Varying Strength and Return Frequency

From figure 10 we see that there exists a field strength threshold B_{0c} such that for $B_0 < B_{0c}$ the flock remains aligned (predator not detected), and for $B_0 > B_{0c}$ the flock rapidly dis-aligns (predator detected), before returning to alignment once it has passed. Additionally, from figure 10b we see that for very high frequency attacks the flock never gets a chance to recover, and remains dis-aligned, while for low-frequency attacks, the flock has time to recover and align between attacks. In this context it is unlikely that a predator is leaving and coming back to attack 1000 times a second, but These high-frequency scenarios should be taken as when the predator is rapidly changing direction while inside the flock itself.

5 Conclusion

From the analysis of SOS and Heisenberg models we have successfully developed a rigorous mathematical framework for modeling bird flocking behavior. A key caveat of this work is that almost all analyses in sections 3 and 4 were reliant on Assumption (2.7) which states that the relative positions of birds in a flock remain constant over short-time, while only relative headings change, this allows us to decouple the position and heading dynamics, and solve both models on a lattice structure greatly simplifying nearest neighbor interactions. An obvious extension would be to try to analyze dynamics without this assumption, however I anticipate such an analysis would be significantly less rigorous and more reliant on computational experiments.

A final note I would like to add is that if I had more time I would have really liked to reduce to try to see if these results generalize to higher dimensions, and while I don't expect there to be 13 dimensional bird flocks any time soon, I noticed certain interesting behaviors both numerically and analytically when trying to generalize to more dimensions. For example the global asymptotic stability result in theorem 3.5 is reliant on the interaction matrix R being overlapping and implicitly the number of orthogonal vectors in $\mathbb{R}^3$ is 3 is less than the number of nearest neighbors (6), however In lower (and perhaps higher with different interaction structures) dimension this result is not necessarily true so the proof could be invalid and you could potentially have non-aligned stable states which would be interesting to look into.

If you would like to look into any computational experiments used for this experiment I have attached an anonymized github link here:

<https://anonymous.4open.science/r/Ph-11-ImDaBiggestBird-A63D/>

6 AI Use Disclaimer

ChatGPT was used for very specific parts of this project. The following are the ONLY parts which AI was in any way involved with:

- The Tikz drawing in figure 2 was generated with the help of ChatGPT.
- The formatting to get the subfigures in figure 3 and 6 side by side was assisted by ChatGPT.
- As noted in the header notes of the HG.py and SOS.py, AI was used to help write certain plotting and visualization functions, however all computational experiments, testing, and analysis were written SOLELY by me
- An online template and AI were used at the very beginning of this project to format a blank latex document with formatting, but absolutely no content was populated during this phase
- Used Grammarly spell check ONLY for grammar check (no clarity or rewriting)

References

- [Bal+08] M. Ballerini et al. “Interaction ruling animal collective behavior depends on topological rather than metric distance: Evidence from a field study”. In: *Proc. Natl. Acad. Sci. U.S.A.* 105.4 (2008), pp. 1232–1237. DOI: 10.1073/pnas.0711437105. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.0711437105>.
- [Beh+16] Malte Behrmann et al. “Versatile Approach to the Spin Dynamics in Correlated Electron Systems”. In: *Physical Review B* 94 (Feb. 2016). DOI: 10.1103/PhysRevB.94.165120.
- [DP04] Sushanta Dattagupta and Sanjay Puri. “Kinetic Ising Models”. In: *Dissipative Phenomena in Condensed Matter: Some Applications*. Berlin, Heidelberg: Springer Berlin Heidelberg, 2004, pp. 31–55. ISBN: 978-3-662-06758-1. DOI: 10.1007/978-3-662-06758-1_2. URL: https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-662-06758-1_2.
- [Gla63] Roy J. Glauber. “Time-Dependent Statistics of the Ising Model”. In: *Journal of Mathematical Physics* 4.2 (Feb. 1963), pp. 294–307. ISSN: 0022-2488. DOI: 10.1063/1.1703954. eprint: https://pubs.aip.org/aip/jmp/article-pdf/4/2/294/19156949/294_1_online.pdf. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1063/1.1703954>.
- [Mur03] R. M. Murray. *Lyapunov Stability Theory*. /mnt/data/mls93-lyap.pdf. Lecture or excerpt on Lyapunov stability theory. Author and publication details not provided in the document. 2003.
- [NJ89] J.M. Nunes Da Silva and E.J.S. Jage. “Glauber dynamics in the Ising chain with random transition rates”. In: *Physics Letters A* 135.1 (1989), pp. 17–19. ISSN: 0375-9601. DOI: [https://doi.org/10.1016/0375-9601\(89\)90717-2](https://doi.org/10.1016/0375-9601(89)90717-2). URL: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/0375960189907172>.
- [Olf06] Reza Olfati-Saber. “Swarms on Sphere: A Programmable Swarm with Synchronous Behaviors like Oscillator Networks”. In: *Proceedings of the 45th IEEE Conference on Decision and Control*. San Diego, CA: IEEE, 2006, pp. 5060–5066. URL: <https://api.semanticscholar.org/CorpusID:12476303>.
- [PH77] Harold Pomeroy and Frank Heppner. “Laboratory determination of startle reaction time of the starling (*Sturnus vulgaris*)”. In: *Animal Behaviour* 25 (1977), pp. 720–725. ISSN: 0003-3472. DOI: [https://doi.org/10.1016/0003-3472\(77\)90121-X](https://doi.org/10.1016/0003-3472(77)90121-X). URL: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/000334727790121X>.

- [Pir21] Antonio Sergio Teixeira Pires. *The Heisenberg model*. 2053-2563. IOP Publishing, 2021, 1-1 to 1-16. ISBN: 978-0-7503-3879-0. DOI: 10.1088/978-0-7503-3879-0ch1. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1088/978-0-7503-3879-0ch1>.
- [You25] YouTube. *Swarm Video*. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UVko9jyAkQg&t=205s>. Accessed: November 24, 2025. 2025.